



4 Comparative essay: narrative or dramatic technique (Paper 2)

Paper 2 · Comparative essay · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Some Paper 2 questions ask you to compare how two works use narrative or dramatic technique (e.g. point of view, structure, staging, dialogue) to shape meaning, rather than focusing primarily on theme. This requires precise terminology for technique and a clear account of the effect each choice produces, so that the essay compares craft as well as content — for instance, contrasting an unreliable first-person narrator with an objective third-person narrator, or contrasting fragmented dramatic structure with linear plotting.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Essay question: Compare how two works use narrative perspective to control the reader's sympathy. Model comparative point: 'Where the first work's first-person narrator withholds key information to manipulate the reader's sympathy retrospectively, the second work's shifting third-person perspective distributes sympathy across multiple characters simultaneously, so that the reader's loyalty is never allowed to settle on a single figure.' This compares technique (narrative perspective) and effect (control of sympathy) directly.

Quick check · multiple choice

An 'unreliable narrator' is best defined as:

- A A narrator who speaks in the third person only
- B A narrator whose credibility is compromised, so the reader must question or look beyond their account
- C Any narrator who uses figurative language
- D A narrator who appears in more than one chapter

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Using two generic literary forms (for example, a novel and a play) that you have studied, write a comparative essay plan for the question: 'Compare how two works use structure (chronological or non-chronological) to shape the reader's or audience's understanding of a central event.' Use placeholder descriptions rather than naming real texts. [20]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

Introduction: thesis contrasting a linear structure's effect (e.g. building suspense toward the event) with a non-linear structure's effect (e.g. reframing the event once its consequences are already known).

- Body 1: compare how each work introduces the central event structurally (foreshadowed gradually vs revealed out of chronological order) and the effect on audience expectation.
- Body 2: compare a specific structural technique in each work (e.g. flashback, foreshadowing, act/scene division, chapter breaks) and how it manages information and tension.
- Body 3: compare how structure affects the audience's or reader's moral judgement of characters involved in the event — does delayed or reordered information change sympathy or blame?
- Conclusion: argue which structural approach the essay finds more effective for the specific thematic concern, while acknowledging both are valid authorial choices suited to their form.

Quick check answer

B. Unreliability refers to a narrator whose perspective, honesty, or judgement the reader is invited to question, not to person or frequency of appearance.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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